BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · SALES

Financial-Services & Fintech Sales

Selling BFSI products and BFSI technology in India — the domain where a finance-plus-tech background is a genuine edge.

Target roles: Relationship Manager · Sales/BD Executive · Inside Sales · SDR (fintech) · Key Account & Partnerships
Candidate profile: MBA Finance · NISM Series-XV (SRI & Sustainability) certified · pursuing NISM Series X-A (Investment Adviser) · ex-D.E. Shaw F&O desk · CS undergraduate
Context: India · INR · compliance-aware · ethics-first

Contents

1. Why this is *your* subject: the finance-plus-tech edge

Most people who apply for sales roles in banks, broking houses and fintechs are generalists. They can talk to people, they are hungry, they will chase a target — but when a prospect asks a sharp question about how a product actually works, they reach for a script. You are different, and the whole point of this guide is to make you use that difference deliberately.

You bring three things that are rare in the same person:

- **Finance domain fluency.** You did an MBA in Finance and you sat on a Futures & Options desk at D.E. Shaw, one of the most quantitative firms in the world. You understand what a mutual fund *is*, what an option Greek does, why a portfolio needs rebalancing, what "expense ratio" costs a client over ten years, and why leverage cuts both ways. Most sales reps memorise these words; you actually understand them.
- **Quantitative and analytical skill.** A computer-science undergraduate degree plus a derivatives desk means you can model, you can read data, you can build a returns comparison in a spreadsheet in five minutes, and you can tell a compelling story with numbers. In BFSI sales, the person who can quantify the value proposition wins.
- **Regulatory literacy.** You are NISM Series-XV certified and pursuing the NISM Series X-A Investment Adviser certification. You know that SEBI, RBI and IRDAI exist, that suitability is a legal obligation and not a slogan, and that mis-selling has consequences. Compliance-aware salespeople are trusted with bigger clients.

The strategic insight for your whole career pivot: **sell into the domain you already understand.** A generalist SDR selling generic B2B software has no moat. You selling a trading platform to active traders, a wealth product to an investor, or a lending API to an NBFC's product head — that is a person talking to a buyer in the buyer's own language. That is your differentiator, and this guide is built entirely around it.

> **Key takeaways:** Your edge is not "I can sell." It is "I understand this product and this buyer better than the average rep, and I am compliance-aware." In every interview and every sales conversation, lead with domain fluency + analytics + regulatory literacy. Never apologise for pivoting from a desk role into sales — reframe it as bringing the desk's rigour to the front line.

2. The Indian financial-services sales landscape

"Financial services" in India is not one market — it is a stack of sub-industries, each with its own products, regulators, sales motions and career ladders. Understanding the map is the first thing an interviewer will test, because it tells them whether you actually want *this* job or just *a* job.

2.1 The main sub-industries

- **Banks** (HDFC, ICICI, Axis, SBI, Kotak, plus foreign banks). They sell savings/current accounts, fixed deposits, loans, credit cards, and — through their wealth arms — mutual funds, insurance and PMS. Sales roles range from branch RMs to Priority/Preferred/Private banking RMs.
- **NBFCs** (Bajaj Finance, Shriram, Muthoot, Cholamandalam). Non-bank lenders focused on consumer durables loans, personal loans, gold loans, vehicle and SME finance. Heavy field-sales and DSA (direct selling agent) culture.
- **AMCs / Mutual Funds** (HDFC AMC, ICICI Pru AMC, SBI MF, Nippon India, Axis MF). They manufacture mutual fund schemes and distribute them through banks, IFAs (independent financial advisers), and direct/online channels. Sales here is often B2B2C — you sell *through* distributors, or you are a distributor.
- **Insurance** — life (LIC, HDFC Life, SBI Life, ICICI Pru Life, Max Life) and general/health (Star Health, ICICI Lombard, HDFC Ergo, Niva Bupa). Sold via agency force, bancassurance, brokers and increasingly online aggregators.
- **Broking** (Zerodha, Groww, Angel One, Upstox, ICICI Direct, Kotak Securities). They open demat/trading accounts and earn on brokerage, and increasingly on subscription, margin funding and cross-sold products.
- **Wealth management / PMS / AIF** (360 ONE formerly IIFL Wealth, Kotak Wealth, ASK, Motilal Oswal PMS, Nuvama). Serves HNIs and ultra-HNIs with discretionary and advisory portfolios, Portfolio Management Services (SEBI minimum ₹50 lakh) and Alternative Investment Funds (typically ₹1 crore minimum).

2.2 Who regulates what — and why it matters to a salesperson

You cannot sell in this domain without knowing which regulator governs which product, because the regulator dictates what you are *allowed* to say. Getting this wrong in an interview is disqualifying; getting it wrong on a client call can get you and your employer fined.

Regulator	Governs	What it means for a seller
SEBI (Securities & Exchange Board of India)	Securities markets: equities, mutual funds, PMS, AIF, broking, Research Analysts, Investment Advisers (RIA)	Distributors must have ARN (AMFI) + pass NISM exams. Advice vs distribution is legally separated. No guaranteed-return claims on market products.
RBI (Reserve Bank of India)	Banks, NBFCs, payment systems, deposits, lending, KYC/AML norms	Governs Digital Lending Guidelines, payment aggregator licences, and the KYC rules every onboarding must follow.
IRDAI (Insurance Regulatory & Development Authority of India)	Life, health and general insurance; agents, brokers, corporate agents	Insurance agents need IRDAI licensing. Strict rules on how returns and benefits are illustrated.
PFRDA	Pension — NPS (National Pension System)	Relevant if you sell retirement/pension products.
AMFI (industry body, SEBI-recognised)	Mutual fund distributor registration (ARN)	To be paid commission on MF distribution you need an ARN, obtained after passing NISM Series V-A.

Common trap: Confusing a *distributor* with an *adviser*. Under SEBI rules these are legally distinct: a mutual-fund distributor (ARN) earns commission from the AMC and can only make "incidental" advice; a Registered Investment Adviser (RIA) charges the client a fee and must act in the client's best interest with documented suitability. You cannot freely do both for the same client. Saying "I'll be their adviser and earn commission" in an interview signals you don't understand the framework.

Key takeaways: Learn the industry map (banks, NBFCs, AMCs, insurance, broking, wealth/PMS) and the regulator for each (RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, PFRDA + AMFI). The regulator defines what you can promise. Distributor ≠ adviser. This vocabulary alone puts you ahead of most fresher applicants.

3. The fintech sales landscape

Fintech is where your CS background compounds with your finance knowledge. Indian fintech splits into recognisable segments, and each segment sells differently. Knowing the segment tells you the buyer, the sales cycle and the metric that matters.

Segment	What they sell	Representative players	Who they sell to
Payments	Payment gateways, UPI, POS, payment aggregation, payouts	Razorpay, PhonePe, Paytm, Cashfree, PayU, BharatPe	Merchants (SMB to enterprise), other businesses (B2B)
Lending / LendingTech	Digital personal/SME loans, BNPL, co-lending, loan origination software (LOS/LMS)	KreditBee, Lendingkart, LendingKart, Yubi (CredAvenue), FinBox	Consumers (B2C) and lenders/NBFCs/banks (B2B infra)
Wealthtech	Investing platforms, MF/stocks, robo-advice, goal-based investing	Groww, Zerodha (Coin), Upstox, INDmoney, Kuvera, smallcase	Retail investors (B2C); some sell APIs to partners (B2B)
Insurtech	Online insurance distribution, comparison, embedded insurance	PolicyBazaar, Acko, Digit, Onsurity	Consumers (B2C); employers (group cover, B2B)
Neobanking	Digital-first banking layers, business banking, spend management	Jupiter, Fi, Open, RazorpayX	Consumers and businesses (current accounts, payroll, cards)
B2B SaaS for BFSI	KYC/onboarding, fraud/risk, core banking, RegTech, AA-based underwriting, trading/OMS	Signzy, HyperVerge, Perfios, M2P, Zeta, Setu, Digio	Banks, NBFCs, insurers, brokers, other fintechs

3.1 B2C fintech sales vs B2B fintech sales

The single most important distinction. In **B2C** (Groww, PhonePe consumer, PolicyBazaar), "sales" is often a blend of performance marketing, inside sales/tele-calling, and activation — high volume, short cycles, driven by funnel metrics. In **B2B** (Razorpay enterprise, M2P, Signzy, Yubi), sales is consultative, multi-stakeholder, months-long, and driven by pipeline and ACV (annual contract value). Freshers enter both; the B2B side is where your domain knowledge is most valuable and least commoditised.

3.2 Why fintech loves your profile specifically

- A payments company selling to merchants values someone who can explain settlement cycles, MDR (merchant discount rate), chargebacks and reconciliation without hand-waving.
- A BFSI-SaaS company selling KYC/onboarding to a bank needs an SDR/AE who can hold a conversation about API integration, TAT (turnaround time), false-positive rates and RBI KYC norms.
- A wealthtech selling to active traders needs someone who has actually watched an options position move — that is *you*.

> **Key takeaways:** Fintech = payments, lending, wealthtech, insurtech, neobanking, BFSI-SaaS. The first question about any fintech role is "B2C or B2B?" — it changes the cycle, the buyer and the metric. Your finance + CS profile is worth the most in B2B fintech and BFSI-SaaS, where domain fluency is scarce.

4. Fresher role types and what each actually does

Job titles in this space are inconsistent. The same work is called "Relationship Manager" at a bank, "Wealth Manager" at a broker, "Sales Executive" at an NBFC and "Account Executive" at a fintech. Learn the *function*, not the title.

Role	What you actually do	Typical employer	Core metric
Relationship Manager (RM)	Own a book of clients; acquire, retain, deepen; needs-based selling and cross-sell of MF/insurance/loans	Banks, wealth firms, brokers	AUM growth, cross-sell ratio, revenue per client, retention
Sales / BD Executive	Acquire new customers/merchants/borrowers; field or phone; hit monthly targets	NBFCs, payments, insurance	Accounts/loans/merchants added, disbursal value
Inside Sales / Tele-sales	Convert inbound leads by phone; qualify, demo, close smaller deals	Fintech B2C, wealthtech	Conversion %, revenue, talk-time, activations
SDR / BDR (Sales/Business Development Rep)	Prospect & qualify leads for closers; book meetings; outbound email/call/LinkedIn	B2B fintech, BFSI-SaaS	Qualified meetings (SQLs) booked, pipeline generated
Account Executive (AE)	Own the full B2B deal from qualified lead to close; demos, POCs, negotiation	B2B fintech, SaaS	New ACV / bookings, win rate, sales cycle length
Key Account / Partnerships	Grow existing large accounts or sign channel/co-brand partners	Payments, lending infra, AMCs	Net revenue retention, partner-sourced revenue

The realistic entry points for you: RM at a bank/broker/wealth firm; Inside Sales at a wealthtech (you can speak to investors credibly); or — the strongest fit — SDR/BDR at a B2B fintech or BFSI-SaaS company, with a fast path to AE because you can carry a domain conversation that most SDRs cannot. Do not be shy about targeting the B2B path; it has the best ceiling and best fit for your profile.

> **Common trap:** Treating an SDR role as "just booking meetings" and beneath an ex-D.E. Shaw candidate. SDR is the standard on-ramp to B2B tech sales in India and globally; strong performers promote to AE in 9–18 months, and the AE track leads to enterprise sales and sales leadership with excellent earnings. Snobbery about the entry title is the fastest way to lose the offer.

> **Key takeaways:** Learn the function behind the title. Your best-fit entry roles are RM (relationship depth), Inside Sales at a wealthtech (investor conversations), or SDR/BDR at B2B fintech (domain-heavy prospecting → AE). Match your pitch to the role's core metric.

5. Selling financial products: value props, motivations, objections

You must be able to sell each major retail product on *needs*, not features — and you must know the honest objections, because handling them is where trust is built. This table is worth memorising; interviewers love "sell me this product" and buyers test you on the objections.

Product	Core value proposition (needs-based)	Buyer motivation	Typical objections
Mutual funds (SIP)	Disciplined, diversified, professionally managed wealth creation for goals; low ticket via SIP; liquid	Beat inflation, retirement, child's education, don't have time/skill to pick stocks	"Market is risky", "returns not guaranteed", "I'll lose money", "why not FD?"
Term life insurance	Pure income protection: large cover for a small premium so family is secure if income stops	Dependents, home loan, sole earner, peace of mind	"No returns if I survive", "too young to need it", "I have employer cover"
Health insurance	Protects savings from medical shock; cashless hospitalisation; rising healthcare costs	Family health, hospital-cost inflation, tax benefit	"I'm healthy", "employer covers me", "claims get rejected"
Equity / demat account	Direct market access, low brokerage, tools to invest and trade	Wealth creation, control, active interest in markets	"I don't understand markets", "too risky", "hidden charges"
Personal loan / credit card	Immediate liquidity/convenience; build credit; rewards	Emergency, purchase, cash-flow smoothing	"Interest too high", "debt trap", "hidden fees"
Wealth / advisory / PMS	Bespoke portfolio, professional management, holistic planning across assets	Grow & protect large corpus, save time, sophistication	"High fees", "can I trust you", "why not do it myself/direct"

5.1 Features vs benefits vs needs

A **feature** is a fact about the product ("this fund has a 0.5% expense ratio"). A **benefit** is what that does for the buyer ("more of your money stays invested"). A **need** is the buyer's actual problem ("you told me you want ₹50 lakh for your daughter's education in 15 years"). Needs-based selling connects feature → benefit → the client's stated goal. Product-dumping lists features. Always sell the need.

> **The needs-based selling loop**
> Discover (ask & listen) → Diagnose (identify goal, horizon, risk capacity) → Recommend (map product to need) → Justify (numbers & suitability) → Document (KYC + rationale) → Review (portfolio review, adjust)
>
> where: the discover step should take the most time. Amateurs pitch first; professionals diagnose first.

> **Common trap — product-dumping vs needs-based:** Walking in and reciting "our fund gave 18% last year, invest now." You don't know the client's goal, horizon or risk capacity, past returns don't repeat, and it's non-compliant. Always discover the need before you recommend. If you cannot articulate *why this product suits this client*, you are not selling — you are pushing.

> **Common trap — over-promising returns:** Never say "this will give you 15%" or "guaranteed returns" for any market-linked product. Past performance is not indicative of future results — this is not

just a disclaimer, it is the law and the ethic. Say "historically this category has delivered X over the long term, but returns are market-linked and not guaranteed." Over-promising is the single most common cause of mis-selling complaints and regulatory action.

Key takeaways: Sell needs, not features. Memorise value prop + motivation + objection for each retail product. Two non-negotiable rules: discover before you recommend, and never guarantee market returns. These two habits separate a trusted adviser from a mis-seller.

6. The Relationship Manager (RM) playbook

The RM is the archetypal financial-services sales role and the most likely bank/wealth entry point. An RM owns a *book* — a set of clients — and is measured not on one sale but on the lifetime value of that book. The job is 20% acquiring and 80% deepening and retaining.

6.1 The five jobs of an RM

- **Acquire.** Bring in new clients via referrals, leads, walk-ins, events, cold outreach. Referrals from happy clients are the highest-quality source — engineer them deliberately.
- **Onboard.** Complete KYC, risk profiling and account setup cleanly. A smooth onboarding is the first impression of your competence.
- **Deepen (cross-sell / upsell).** A client with only a savings account is a shallow relationship. Add SIPs, insurance, a demat account, a loan — *where each genuinely fits a need.* "Share of wallet" is the real RM metric.
- **Service.** Resolve issues fast, answer questions, be the human the client trusts. Servicing is what earns the right to cross-sell.
- **Review.** Periodic portfolio reviews — rebalance, capture new goals, demonstrate you are watching. Reviews are also the most natural, non-pushy cross-sell moment.

6.2 The cross-sell mindset (done ethically)

Cross-selling has a bad reputation because it is often done as product-pushing to hit incentives. Done right, it is service: a client who has a home loan almost certainly *needs* term insurance and health cover to protect the family that lives in that home. Surfacing that is good advice that also grows your book. The test is always: *would I recommend this if I earned nothing on it?*

Worked Example — an ethical portfolio review that cross-sells

Situation: Priya, 32, salaried, ₹18 LPA, married, one child. Currently holds only an FD (₹6 lakh) and a savings account with your bank. It's her annual review.

Discover: "Priya, before we look at numbers — what are you saving *for*? What would worry you if it went wrong?" She says: child's education (~15 years away), and she worries the family depends entirely on her husband's income.

Diagnose: Two clear gaps — (1) an FD alone won't beat education inflation over 15 years; (2) no income protection despite single-earner dependency.

Recommend, mapped to needs: (a) Start a ₹15,000/month SIP into a diversified equity fund for the 15-year education goal — long horizon suits equity. (b) A term plan on her husband for ~₹1.5 crore cover at a small premium. (c) A family-floater health policy. Keep the FD as the emergency buffer.

Justify with numbers & suitability: Show the SIP projection using an *assumed, clearly-labelled* long-term return (e.g. "assuming ~11% p.a., not guaranteed"), and the FD's likely real return after inflation. Document her risk profile and the rationale.

Outcome: You have deepened the relationship with three products — *all of which she genuinely needed*. That is the RM playbook working as intended.

Common trap: Cross-selling to the incentive, not the need — e.g. pushing a high-commission ULIP or endowment plan when a low-cost term plan + mutual fund would serve the client far better. This is the classic Indian mis-selling pattern (bundling insurance as "investment"). It generates complaints, chargebacks of commission, and destroys the referral engine that actually makes RMs successful.

Key takeaways: An RM owns a book and is paid on its lifetime value. The five jobs: acquire, onboard, deepen, service, review. Cross-sell is service when it maps to a real need — apply the "would I recommend this if I earned nothing?" test. Referrals from delighted clients are the highest-ROI acquisition channel; engineer them.

7. B2B fintech / SaaS-for-BFSI selling

This is the highest-ceiling path for your profile. Selling software or infrastructure to banks, NBFCs, insurers and fintechs is a different sport from retail: bigger deals, longer cycles, multiple decision-makers, and technical/compliance depth as a *selling* advantage rather than a hurdle.

7.1 What makes B2B BFSI sales different

- **Long cycles.** A payments or KYC deal with a bank can take 3–12 months. You manage a pipeline over quarters, not a monthly target of walk-ins.
- **Multiple stakeholders.** You are rarely selling to one person. There is a *business* buyer (who wants the outcome — more conversions, lower fraud), a *technical* buyer (IT/engineering — who cares about APIs, uptime, integration effort), a *compliance/risk* buyer (who cares about RBI/SEBI norms, data residency, audit), a *procurement* buyer (price, contract), and an *economic* buyer (who signs — often a CXO). You must map and win each.
- **POCs and pilots.** BFSI buyers de-risk with a proof-of-concept or a limited pilot before a full rollout. Running a clean POC with clear success criteria is a core B2B sales skill.
- **Integration / API selling.** You are often selling something that must plug into their systems. Being able to talk about REST APIs, SDKs, webhooks, sandbox environments, uptime SLAs and integration timelines — *your CS background* — builds instant credibility with the technical buyer.
- **Security & compliance as sales topics.** In BFSI, "are you SOC 2 / ISO 27001 certified?", "where is data stored?", "are you RBI-compliant for data localisation?", "how do you handle PII?" are *sales questions*. The rep who answers them confidently advances the deal; the one who says "let me check" stalls it.

7.2 A simple B2B qualification framework

> MEDDIC (adapted for BFSI SaaS)
>
> Metrics (what business number improves?) · Economic buyer (who signs?) · Decision criteria (what must be true to buy?) · Decision process (steps, POC, compliance sign-off, procurement) · Identify pain (the real problem) · Champion (who inside sells for you?)
>
> where: in BFSI, always add an explicit Compliance/Security gate to the Decision process — deals die there if you ignore it.

A lighter, common alternative for early-stage qualification is **BANT** (Budget, Authority, Need, Timeline). SDRs often qualify on BANT; AEs run MEDDIC through the deal.

7.3 The B2B sales funnel and where a fresher fits

> B2B pipeline stages
>
> Prospect → Connect → Qualify (SDR hands off) → Discovery → Demo → POC/Pilot → Proposal → Security & Compliance review → Procurement/Legal → Closed-Won → Onboard/Expand
>
> where: as an SDR you own Prospect→Qualify; as an AE you own Discovery→Closed-Won. Knowing the whole map makes you a better SDR because you qualify for what the AE needs.

> **Key takeaways:** B2B BFSI sales = long cycles, multi-stakeholder (business + IT + compliance + procurement + economic buyer), POC-driven, integration/API-heavy, with security & compliance as live selling topics. Qualify with BANT/MEDDIC and always add a compliance gate. Your CS +

> finance background lets you speak credibly to the technical and compliance buyers — that is rare and valuable.

8. Regulation, ethics & suitability — the licence to sell

This section is the one most sales guides skip and the one that will most impress a BFSI interviewer. In financial services, compliance is not a department that slows you down — it is the thing that lets you sell at all, and it is a genuine *trust asset* in front of clients. Your NISM certifications signal you take it seriously.

8.1 Suitability & appropriateness

Suitability means the product must fit the specific client's needs, financial situation, risk tolerance and goals. **Appropriateness** means the client understands the product's risks and it is appropriate for their knowledge/experience. A 60-year-old retiree living on interest should not be sold a leveraged equity F&O strategy — not because it's illegal to trade, but because it is *unsuitable*. Advisers are legally obliged to assess and document suitability.

8.2 Mis-selling — what it is and why it's punished

Mis-selling is selling a product through misrepresentation, by hiding costs/risks, or by pushing something unsuitable to earn commission. Classic Indian examples: selling ULIPs/endowment plans as "guaranteed high-return investments"; churning a portfolio to generate brokerage; selling a single-premium insurance to an elderly person as a fixed deposit. It is punished because it destroys trust in the entire financial system — and consequences include SEBI/IRDAI/RBI penalties, clawed-back commissions, termination, and reputational ruin. For you, one mis-selling complaint early in a career can be devastating; a clean, advisory reputation compounds.

8.3 SEBI Investment Adviser (RIA) framework & where you stand

SEBI's Investment Adviser Regulations created the **Registered Investment Adviser (RIA)** — a fee-only fiduciary who must act in the client's best interest, keep advice and distribution separate, and document suitability. To move toward advisory roles you must clear the **NISM Series X-A (Investment Adviser Level 1)** and X-B (Level 2) exams (plus experience/net-worth criteria for actual RIA registration). **You are currently pursuing NISM Series X-A — mention it as in-progress, not completed.** You *hold* NISM Series-XV (SRI & Sustainability), which is a genuine, current credential and a differentiator in the ESG/sustainable-investing conversation.

8.4 Distributor vs adviser vs conflicts of interest

	Distributor (MF, insurance agent)	Registered Investment Adviser (RIA)
Paid by	The manufacturer (commission/brokerage)	The client (advisory fee)
Duty	Suitability; advice must be "incidental"	Fiduciary — client's best interest
Credential	ARN (MF) / IRDAI licence (insurance)	SEBI RIA registration (NISM X-A & X-B)
Conflict	Commission can bias product choice — must be managed & disclosed	Fee-only design removes product-commission conflict

8.5 KYC / AML and onboarding as part of the sale

KYC (Know Your Customer) and **AML** (Anti-Money-Laundering) are not back-office chores that happen after the sale — they are *part* of the sale. No account, SIP, insurance policy or merchant onboarding is complete without KYC. A salesperson who guides a client through KYC smoothly (PAN, Aadhaar/e-KYC, in-person or video verification, FATCA declaration) closes faster and cleaner. For a payments fintech onboarding a merchant, KYB (Know Your Business) and risk categorisation are literally the last mile of the deal. Understanding this makes you the rep whose deals actually convert, not the one whose "closed" deals get stuck in onboarding.

Common trap — ignoring compliance to close: Rushing or fudging KYC, back-dating forms, or telling a client "just sign, I'll handle the paperwork" to hit a month-end target. In BFSI this is career-ending: it exposes the firm to AML penalties and you to termination and worse. Compliance-aware selling is *faster* in the long run because clean deals don't unwind.

Key takeaways: Suitability + appropriateness are legal duties, not slogans. Mis-selling is punished because it breaks systemic trust — avoid it absolutely. Distributor (commission) ≠ RIA (fee, fiduciary). KYC/AML is part of the sale, not after it. You hold NISM Series-XV; you are *pursuing* NISM X-A (Investment Adviser) — state it accurately. Compliance literacy is a trust asset you can sell with.

9. Positioning your background: turning your CV into pipeline

Now we operationalise the edge from Section 1. Positioning is the deliberate framing you use in interviews, on LinkedIn, and on the first 30 seconds of every sales call. Your raw materials: MBA Finance, NISM Series-XV, pursuing NISM X-A, ex-D.E. Shaw F&O desk, CS undergrad.

9.1 The reframes that win

They might think...	You reframe as...
"Ex-desk, quiet analyst — can he sell?"	"I've operated in high-pressure, real-money environments where being wrong costs. I bring that discipline to hitting targets — and I can talk to buyers in their own language."
"Fresher in sales — no track record"	"I don't need to learn the *product* from scratch like most freshers — I already understand markets, risk and instruments. I only need to learn *your* sales process, and I learn fast."
"Why leave finance for sales?"	"I realised the part I loved was translating complex products into decisions people act on. That's sales — and I'd rather do it where my finance depth is an edge."
"CS background — why not engineering?"	"It means I can hold my own with a client's IT team on APIs and integration — which in fintech sales closes deals that a non-technical rep stalls."

9.2 Your three-sentence positioning statement

Your elevator positioning (memorise and adapt)

"I'm an MBA-Finance professional with a computer-science background who spent time on D.E. Shaw's F&O desk, so I understand financial products from the inside — the maths, the risk, and the regulation. I'm NISM Series-XV certified and pursuing the NISM Investment Adviser certification. I'm pivoting into business development because I'm best at translating complex financial and fintech products into value that a client or a business can actually act on — and I want to do that where deep domain knowledge is an advantage, not where it's wasted."

> **Key takeaways:** Positioning is deliberate framing you repeat everywhere. Reframe "quiet analyst" as "disciplined operator who speaks the buyer's language," and "fresher" as "already fluent in the product." Memorise a three-sentence statement and adapt it to each employer's segment.

10. Sample pitches

These are the set pieces. Practise them aloud until they're natural, then flex them to the specific prospect. Note how each one *discovers before recommending* and stays compliant.

Pitch A — Wealth / Mutual Fund pitch to a retail client (needs-based, compliant)

Prospect: Rahul, 28, software engineer, ₹12 LPA, keeps ₹4 lakh idle in a savings account, "wants to start investing but doesn't know where."

Open (permission + discovery): "Rahul, before I suggest anything — can I ask what you're hoping this money does for you? Is there a goal, or is it more 'I want it to grow instead of sitting idle'?" *[Listen. He says: a house down-payment in ~5 years, and generally growing money.]*

Diagnose & educate: "Right now ₹4 lakh in savings earns maybe 3% — after inflation, it's actually losing value. For a 5-year goal, a mix of equity and debt mutual funds via SIP is a sensible fit: you invest a fixed amount monthly, it's professionally managed, diversified, and you can start with as little as ₹5,000."

Recommend, mapped to the goal: "For the house goal, I'd suggest a balanced approach — not aggressive equity, because 5 years isn't very long. Keep an emergency buffer of ~₹1 lakh liquid, and start a ₹20,000/month SIP split across a large-cap and a hybrid fund."

Compliant framing of returns: "I want to be straight with you: these are market-linked, so returns aren't guaranteed and there will be ups and downs. Historically this kind of portfolio has done meaningfully better than an FD over 5+ years, but I can't promise a number — anyone who does is misleading you."

Close to next step: "If that makes sense, the next step is a quick risk-profiling and KYC — takes 15 minutes online — and we can start the first SIP this month so you don't lose time. Shall we?"

Pitch B — B2B fintech pitch to a business buyer (payment gateway)

Prospect: Head of Product at a fast-growing D2C brand doing ₹5 crore/month online, currently on a legacy gateway with a ~7% checkout drop-off and slow settlements.

Open with a business insight, not a feature: "I looked at your checkout before this call. You're on a redirect-based flow — the industry sees roughly 5–8% of customers abandon at that redirect. On ₹5 crore a month, even a 3-point recovery is ~₹15 lakh of monthly GMV you're currently leaking. That's what I want to talk about, not features."

Discovery (multi-stakeholder): "Who owns checkout conversion on your side — is that you, or growth? And separately, who signs off on a payments change from a security/compliance angle?" *[Maps the business buyer, the tech buyer, the compliance gate.]*

Value + integration (speak to the tech buyer): "Our gateway is a native, on-page checkout with UPI, cards, and 20+ methods, one-tap for returning users. Integration is a REST API with SDKs and a sandbox — your team can be live in a few days, not weeks. Settlements are T+1, and reconciliation is automated so your finance team stops doing it in spreadsheets."

Compliance/security (pre-empt the gate): "On compliance — we're a RBI-authorised payment aggregator, PCI-DSS Level 1, and I can send our security documentation to your team so that review starts in parallel and doesn't hold up go-live."

Propose a low-risk next step: "I'm not asking you to rip anything out. Let's run a two-week A/B pilot on 10% of traffic and measure conversion and settlement against your current provider. If it doesn't move the number, you've lost nothing. Can we get your tech lead on a 30-minute scoping call this week?"

Pitch C — Handling "why should I trust a fresher with my money / my business?"

For a retail client (their money): "That's a fair question and I'd ask it too. Two things. First, I don't act alone — every recommendation I make is a suitable, documented fit for your goals, and it's backed by my firm's research and processes, plus the regulator's suitability rules. Second, honestly, my background is finance and markets — I sat on a derivatives desk at D.E. Shaw and I'm NISM-certified — so you're not getting someone who learned this last month. And I'd rather under-promise and keep you for ten years than oversell and lose you. Test me on a small step first."

For a business buyer (their business): "You're not betting on me — you're betting on a two-week pilot with a clear success metric and no lock-in. My job is to make that pilot easy and honest. And on the technical side, I have a computer-science background, so when your engineers ask about the API or data handling, you're not going to get 'I'll check and revert' — you'll get a real answer or a fast one. Judge me on how I run the pilot."

Why this works: it (1) validates the concern, (2) shifts trust from *the person* to *the process/small reversible step*, and (3) uses your genuine credentials without overclaiming. Never get defensive; the calm answer *is* the credibility.

Common trap: Answering the trust objection by overcompensating — inflating your experience, name-dropping excessively, or promising outsized results to seem impressive. This backfires: sophisticated buyers smell it. The winning move is the opposite — acknowledge the concern, shrink the ask to a reversible first step, and let a small proof do the persuading.

> **Key takeaways:** Every pitch: discover before recommending, quantify the value, stay compliant on returns/claims, and close to a small next step (KYC/SIP for retail; a scoped pilot for B2B). For the trust objection, validate it, move trust to the process and a reversible step, and use real credentials without inflation.

11. Target employers in India and the roles they hire freshers into

Illustrative, not exhaustive — and note that hiring needs change. The point is to show which *type* of company hires freshers into which *type* of role, so you can target and tailor.

Company / type	Segment	Fresher-friendly BD/sales roles
Zerodha, Groww, Upstox, Angel One	Broking / wealthtech (B2C)	Inside sales, customer/account activation, partnerships (for the more B2B-leaning ones)
Razorpay, Cashfree, PayU	Payments (B2B/B2B2C)	SDR/BDR, inside sales, SMB account executive, merchant onboarding
PhonePe, Paytm	Payments / super-app	Field sales (merchant acquisition), inside sales, key accounts
Lendingkart, KreditBee, Yubi, FinBox	Lending / lendingtech	Sales executive (B2C loans), B2B partnerships / enterprise sales (infra)
PolicyBazaar, Acko, Digit, Onsurity	Insurtech	Inside sales (very large fresher intake), B2B group-insurance sales
Signzy, HyperVerge, Perfios, M2P, Zeta, Setu	BFSI SaaS / infra	SDR/BDR → AE, partnerships, solution/pre-sales support
HDFC/ICICI/Axis/Kotak (banks), 360 ONE, Nuvama, Motilal Oswal	Banks & wealth	Relationship Manager, Wealth RM (trainee), acquisition RM

How to target given your profile, in priority order:

1. **BFSI-SaaS / B2B fintech SDR→AE** (Signzy, M2P, Perfios, Setu, Razorpay enterprise, Yubi) — best fit: your CS + finance + compliance literacy is a real moat here.
2. **Wealthtech inside sales / partnerships** (Groww, smallcase, INDmoney) — you can speak to investors and traders credibly.
3. **Bank / wealth RM trainee programmes** — structured, teach you the RM playbook, respected on a CV; a strong classical foundation.

> **Key takeaways:** Match company type to role type. Prioritise B2B fintech / BFSI-SaaS (SDR→AE) where your profile is a moat; then wealthtech inside sales; then bank/wealth RM programmes for structured training. Always tailor the application to the segment's buyer and metric.

12. The 30-60-90 day plan for a new BD hire

Bring this to interviews — literally offer to walk through "here's how I'd approach my first 90 days." It signals seriousness and self-direction, which hiring managers love. Below is a template you can adapt to either a fintech B2B (SDR/AE) or a retail RM role.

30-60-90 Day Plan — new BD/Sales hire (adapt to role)

Days 1–30 — LEARN (absorb product, process, market):

- Master the product cold: complete all training, use the product yourself, be able to demo/explain it and its top 3 differentiators vs competitors.
- Learn the ICP (ideal customer profile), buyer personas, and the exact sales process/CRM/tools your team uses.
- Shadow top performers on 15–20 calls/meetings; document what good looks like — openings, discovery questions, objection handling.
- Learn the compliance/onboarding flow end-to-end (KYC/KYB, what legal/security review needs) so my deals don't stall later.
- *Metric:* product certification passed; 20 calls shadowed; ICP + objection doc written.

Days 31–60 — CONTRIBUTE (start producing under guidance):

- Own my activity: build a prospect list against the ICP; start outbound (calls/emails/LinkedIn) or, for RM, begin client meetings/reviews.
- Run my first discovery calls/demos with a manager listening; iterate on the pitch weekly from feedback.
- Book first qualified meetings (SDR) / open first opportunities / start first SIP or account (RM).
- Build a referral/ask motion and a simple follow-up cadence so nothing leaks.
- *Metric:* hit ~70–80% of a ramped activity target; first qualified pipeline / first accounts opened.

Days 61–90 — PERFORM (hit ramped targets, build engine):

- Hit the ramped quota/target for the period; have a repeatable daily/weekly routine.
- Advance 2–3 real opportunities toward close/pilot (B2B) or complete several full needs-based sales with clean KYC (retail).
- Analyse my own funnel (where do I lose deals?) and fix the weakest stage.
- Establish a referral loop and a territory/account plan for the next quarter.
- *Metric:* at/near full ramped target; a documented pipeline plan for Q2; clear self-diagnosis of my funnel.

> **Key takeaways:** 30 = learn (product, ICP, process, compliance flow); 60 = contribute (outbound/meetings under guidance, first pipeline); 90 = perform (hit ramped target, build a repeatable engine, self-diagnose the funnel). Bringing this plan to an interview is itself a sales move.

13. Interview Q&A bank

Model answers below. Adapt the wording to sound like you — but keep the structure, the numbers-thinking, and the compliance awareness, because those are what set you apart.

13.1 Motivation & the pivot

Q1. Why sales after an MBA in Finance and a role at D.E. Shaw?

A: Because the part of finance I'm best at and most enjoy is translating something complex into a decision someone can act on. On the desk I understood products deeply but I was one step removed from the client. Sales puts me where my finance depth is an actual advantage — I'd rather sell where I understand the product cold than be a generalist. It's a deliberate move toward my strength, not away from finance.

Q2. Isn't this a step down from a quant desk?

A: I don't see it that way. Sales in BFSI has one of the highest ceilings in the industry — top AEs and sales leaders earn and grow enormously — and it's directly tied to value creation. I'm bringing desk-level rigour to a front-line role, which is uncommon. I measure a role by its ceiling and fit, and this fits my strengths better than staying on a desk.

Q3. What makes you think you can sell — you've been an analyst?

A: Two things. One, selling financial products is fundamentally about understanding a need and mapping a suitable product to it credibly — that's analysis plus communication, which is exactly my background. Two, I've operated under pressure where being wrong had real cost, so hitting targets and handling rejection doesn't scare me. I'll need to learn your process, and I learn fast — but I don't need to learn the product from zero like most freshers.

Q4. Why our company specifically?

A: [Tailor.] You sell [product] into [segment], and that's a domain where my finance + technical background is a genuine edge, not a nice-to-have. I've used/looked at your product and I have a view on [specific differentiator/gap]. I want to sell something I can speak about credibly, and I can here.

Q5. Where do you see yourself in 3–5 years?

A: Ramping fast as an individual contributor, becoming a top performer on the board, then growing into larger/enterprise accounts or team leadership. In BFSI sales the path from SDR to AE to enterprise/leadership is well-defined, and I want to earn it on results.

13.2 Product & "sell me this"

Q6. Sell me this mutual fund.

A: First I'd resist selling immediately — I'd ask what you're investing for, your time horizon, and how you'd feel if it dropped 15% in a bad year. Say you tell me it's for a goal 10+ years out and you're okay with volatility. Then: a diversified equity fund via SIP fits — you invest monthly, it's professionally managed and diversified, you start small, and over a long horizon equity has historically beaten inflation and FDs by a meaningful margin. I'd be clear it's market-linked and not guaranteed. Then I'd move you to risk-profiling and KYC to start this month. Notice I diagnosed before I recommended — that's how it should be done.

Q7. Sell me this payment gateway.

A: I'd start with your number, not my features: how much are you processing monthly, and what's your checkout drop-off? If you're leaking even 3–5% at checkout, that's real GMV. Our on-page checkout with UPI/cards/one-tap typically lifts conversion, settles T+1, and automates reconciliation. Integration is a simple REST API with a sandbox, and we're an RBI-authorised, PCI-DSS aggregator so your compliance review can run in parallel. I'd propose a two-week A/B pilot on a slice of traffic — measure conversion, no lock-in. The pilot, not my pitch, does the convincing.

Q8. Sell me this term insurance policy.

A: Do you have anyone financially dependent on you — a spouse, kids, parents, a home loan? [Yes.] Then here's the question that matters: if your income stopped tomorrow, how long could they maintain their life? Term insurance solves exactly that — a large cover, say ₹1 crore, for a small annual premium, so your family's future doesn't depend on your survival. It has no maturity payout, and that's the point — it's pure protection, which is why it's cheap. It's the first thing I'd secure before any investment. Shall we check a quote for your age?

Q9. Sell me this demat/broking account.

A: Do you currently invest directly in stocks or ETFs, or only through others? [Not yet.] A demat account gives you direct, low-cost market access with tools to learn as you go — you're not paying layers of intermediary fees. I'd be honest that direct equity needs learning and discipline, so I'd suggest starting small and perhaps via ETFs/index funds. What I won't do is promise you'll make money trading — most beginners don't when they over-trade. If you want control and you'll invest patiently, this is the right tool.

Q10. Sell me a BFSI SaaS product — say a digital KYC/onboarding tool — to a bank.

A: I'd anchor on their pain: what's your current onboarding TAT and drop-off, and what's your KYC cost per customer? If onboarding takes days and loses applicants, our video-KYC and automated document checks cut TAT to minutes and reduce drop-off, while staying RBI-compliant with a full audit trail. I'd bring the compliance team in early because they can kill or unlock the deal, talk integration with IT, and propose a scoped POC on one product line with a clear success metric. In BFSI you sell the outcome to the business, the integration to IT, and the compliance story to risk — all three.

Q11. A client says "just tell me which fund gives the highest return." What do you do?

A: I'd gently reframe: "Highest past return usually means highest risk, and past returns don't predict future ones — chasing last year's topper is one of the most common ways investors lose money." Then I'd redirect to their goal and risk capacity and build a suitable portfolio. Giving them a hot tip to please them would be the easy, wrong, non-compliant answer.

13.3 Objection handling & scenarios

Q12. A prospect says "the market is too risky, I'll just keep my money in an FD." Handle it.

A: I'd validate it, then reframe risk: "FDs feel safe, and for short-term money they are. But there's a hidden risk too — after tax and ~6% inflation, an FD often barely preserves value, so for long-term goals you can quietly lose purchasing power. The real question is matching the tool to the time horizon: FD for near-term, a diversified SIP for long-term goals where volatility smooths out. You don't have to choose all-or-nothing — let's keep your emergency money safe and put only your long-horizon money to work." I never dismiss the concern; I widen the definition of risk.

Q13. "Your fees/charges are too high." (retail or B2B)

A: "Compared to what, and against what value?" For retail I'd show the fee against the outcome and against the cost of doing nothing/doing it badly. For B2B I'd tie price to the business metric — "the pilot showed a 3-point conversion lift worth ₹15 lakh a month; the fee is a fraction of that." Price objections are usually value-not-yet-established objections. I re-establish value before I ever discuss discount, and I never lead with price cuts.

Q14. "Let me think about it / send me an email." Handle the stall.

A: I'd find the real blocker: "Of course — just so I send the right thing, is it the fit, the timing, or something you need to check with someone?" That surfaces whether it's a genuine timing issue, a hidden objection, or a missing stakeholder. Then I'd agree a concrete next step with a date rather than letting it drift into an unanswered email. A vague "I'll think about it" left un-probed is a dead deal.

Q15. A B2B prospect says "we already use a competitor." Now what?

A: Good — that means they have budget and the problem is real. I'd ask what's working and, more usefully, what one thing they wish were better. I'm not trying to rip out an incumbent on day one; I'm looking for the gap — a workflow, a compliance need, a cost, an integration — where we're clearly better, and I'd propose a small pilot on just that. Displacement happens at the seam, not by attacking the whole thing.

Q16. Walk me through how you'd handle a client who's angry about a loss.

A: First, listen fully and acknowledge — don't get defensive or bury them in jargon. Then reground on what we agreed: the goal, the horizon, the risk profile they signed. If the portfolio is still suitable and the loss is normal market movement, I'd show that context calmly and remind them why we're invested for the long term. If something is genuinely wrong or unsuitable, I'd own it and fix it. The relationship is worth more than being right in the moment, and how you handle a drawdown is what earns lifetime loyalty and referrals.

Q17. How do you prospect from a cold start with no leads?

A: I'd build a targeted list against the ICP rather than spraying — for B2B, use LinkedIn, industry directories, event lists, and trigger events (funding, new product, a hire); for retail, referrals, community, and networks. Then a multi-touch cadence (call + email + LinkedIn) with a message tailored to each prospect's likely pain, not a generic blast. Quality of targeting beats volume of activity — though you still need volume.

Q18. How do you handle rejection and a bad month?

A: I treat sales as a process with a known conversion rate — every "no" is data and moves me toward the yes if my activity and quality are right. After a bad month I audit my funnel: is it top-of-funnel volume, qualification, or closing? Then I fix the weakest stage rather than just "trying harder." On the desk I learned not to let one bad day distort the process; same discipline here.

13.4 Regulation, ethics & suitability

Q19. What is mis-selling and how do you avoid it?

A: Mis-selling is selling through misrepresentation, hiding costs or risks, or pushing an unsuitable product for commission — like selling a ULIP as a guaranteed high-return investment, or a single-premium policy to a retiree as an FD. I avoid it by always assessing and documenting suitability, disclosing costs and risks plainly, never guaranteeing market returns, and applying the test "would I recommend this if I earned nothing on it?" It's also just good business — mis-selling destroys the referral engine.

Q20. What's the difference between a distributor and a Registered Investment Adviser?

A: A distributor — like a mutual-fund agent with an ARN — is paid commission by the manufacturer and can only give incidental advice; their duty is suitability. A SEBI Registered Investment Adviser is paid a fee by the client, owes a fiduciary duty to act in the client's best interest, and must keep advice separate from distribution. The RIA model removes the commission conflict. You can't freely be both for the same client.

Q21. What is suitability, and give an example of something unsuitable.

A: Suitability means the product must fit the specific client's goals, financial situation and risk tolerance. Example: recommending a leveraged F&O strategy or a small-cap-heavy portfolio to a 62-year-old retiree living on that corpus is unsuitable, regardless of its return potential, because they can't bear the risk and need capital preservation and income. Suitability, and documenting it, is a legal duty.

Q22. Which certifications do you hold, and what are you pursuing?

A: I hold NISM Series-XV, the Sustainable and Responsible Investment (SRI) & Sustainability certification, which is directly relevant as ESG investing grows. I'm currently pursuing NISM Series X-A, the Investment Adviser Level 1 certification, to deepen my advisory credentials. I also understand the ARN route for mutual-fund distribution and the broader SEBI/RBI/IRDAI framework.

Q23. Why does KYC/AML matter to a salesperson — isn't it operations' job?

A: It's part of my sale, not after it. No account, SIP, policy or merchant goes live without KYC, so if I guide the client through it cleanly, my deal actually closes instead of getting stuck in onboarding. AML matters because a firm that onboards bad actors faces serious penalties. A rep who treats KYC as someone else's problem has a pile of "closed" deals that never funded.

Q24. A client asks you to help them "adjust" some paperwork to get a loan/policy approved faster. What do you do?

A: I decline, clearly and without drama. Falsifying documents is fraud — it risks the client, my firm's licence, and my career, and it's never worth a single deal. I'd explain the correct path and help them meet the genuine requirement. In BFSI, the willingness to say no to the wrong thing is exactly what makes you trustworthy for the right things.

Q25. How would you sell an ULIP or endowment plan ethically, given their reputation?

A: I'd only recommend one where it genuinely fits — and for most clients seeking returns, a term plan plus a mutual fund is cheaper and clearer, so I'd say that. Where a client specifically values a bundled, disciplined, long-horizon insurance-cum-savings product and understands the costs and lower liquidity, it can be appropriate — but I'd disclose charges and surrender terms plainly and never dress it up as a high-return investment. Ethical selling sometimes means recommending the product you earn less on.

13.5 Fintech / B2B specifics

Q26. Who are the stakeholders in a B2B BFSI deal and how do you sell to each?

A: Typically five: the business buyer (sell the outcome — conversion, cost, fraud reduction); the technical buyer in IT (sell integration ease, APIs, uptime, security); the compliance/risk buyer (sell RBI/SEBI compliance, data handling, audit trail); procurement (price, contract, terms); and the economic buyer/CXO who signs (sell ROI and strategic fit). I map all of them early, find an internal champion, and tailor the message to each — a deal dies if you ignore the compliance or technical gate.

Q27. What's a POC/pilot and how do you run one well?

A: A proof-of-concept or pilot is a limited, time-boxed trial so the buyer de-risks before committing. I run it well by agreeing the success metric and scope *before* starting — "if we hit X on Y by date Z, we move to a full rollout" — keeping it small enough to move fast, involving their technical and compliance people early, and driving to a decision at the end rather than letting it drift into an endless free trial.

Q28. How is selling to a fintech/bank different from selling a consumer product?

A: Longer cycles (months, not minutes), multiple stakeholders instead of one buyer, POC-driven proof, integration and security as live topics, and much larger contract values. It rewards patience, pipeline management and domain credibility over pure charisma — which suits my profile. Consumer/B2C sales is higher-volume, shorter-cycle, funnel-and-activation-driven.

Q29. What metrics would you track as an SDR? As an AE? As an RM?

A: As an SDR: activity (calls/emails), qualified meetings booked (SQLs), and pipeline generated. As an AE: new bookings/ACV, win rate, sales-cycle length, and average deal size. As an RM: AUM/book growth, cross-sell ratio, revenue per client, and retention. I'd also watch conversion between each funnel stage to find and fix my weakest step.

Q30. Your CS background — how does it actually help in fintech sales?

A: When the buyer's engineers ask about the API, webhooks, the sandbox, data flows, uptime or security, I can hold that conversation and keep the deal moving instead of saying "let me check and revert," which stalls momentum and credibility. I can also self-serve a lot of product understanding, run a cleaner POC scoping, and translate between the business buyer and the tech buyer. In BFSI-SaaS, that translation ability is a genuine differentiator.

13.6 Behavioural & closing

Q31. Tell me about a time you persuaded someone.

A: [Use a real example — STAR.] On the desk I once had to convince a senior to change an approach I believed was mispriced. I didn't argue louder; I built the case in the language they cared about — the risk numbers — laid out the downside clearly, and proposed a small, reversible test rather than a big switch. They agreed to the test, it validated the view, and we scaled it. That's exactly how I sell: understand what the other side values, quantify it, and de-risk the first step.

Q32. What do you do when you don't know the answer to a client's question?

A: I say so, honestly — "I don't want to guess on something that affects your money/business; let me get you the precise answer." Then I follow up fast, which itself builds trust. Bluffing in BFSI is dangerous because a wrong technical or compliance answer can create real liability. Speed and honesty beat a confident wrong answer.

Q33. How do you organise your day / manage a pipeline?

A: I time-block: prospecting/outreach in a protected morning window, meetings/demos midday, admin and CRM hygiene and follow-ups later. I keep the CRM current because a clean pipeline is how you forecast and spot the deals about to slip. I prioritise by stage and probability — nurture the top of funnel while driving the near-close deals to a decision. On the desk, disciplined routine under pressure was everything; same here.

Q34. What's your biggest weakness for a sales role?

A: Coming from an analytical background, my instinct can be to over-explain the detail when a buyer just needs the decision-relevant point. I'm actively practising being more concise — leading with the "so what" and offering depth only if they want it. It's improving, and honestly my depth is also my edge, so it's about calibrating it, not losing it.

Q35. Close me — why should we hire you over another candidate?

A: Because most candidates can either sell or understand the product — I do both, and I'm compliance-aware, which in BFSI is a trust asset, not overhead. I speak the buyer's language whether that's an investor, a merchant, or a bank's IT and risk team. I'll ramp faster because I'm not learning the product from scratch, and I bring desk-level discipline to hitting targets. Give me a territory and a quarter and I'll show you pipeline. What would you want to see from me in the first 90 days — because I already have a plan.

Q36. Do you have questions for us?

A: Yes — What does a top performer in this role do differently from an average one? What's the ramp and how is success measured at 30/60/90 days? Who are the main stakeholders in a typical deal, and where do deals most often stall? And how does the team stay on the right side of the compliance line while still moving fast? (Asking these signals you think like a seller and a professional.)

> **Key takeaways:** Across every answer: discover before pitching, quantify value, stay compliant, and de-risk the next step. Reframe your background as an edge, never apologise for the pivot, and always bring a plan. Curiosity and honesty (Q32, Q36) read as competence in BFSI.

14. Metrics, vocabulary & a final checklist

14.1 Vocabulary you must own

Term	Meaning
AUM	Assets Under Management — the core RM/wealth scale metric
SIP	Systematic Investment Plan — fixed periodic mutual-fund investment
ARN	AMFI Registration Number — required to distribute mutual funds for commission
RIA	Registered Investment Adviser — SEBI-registered fee-only fiduciary adviser
KYC / KYB / AML	Know Your Customer / Business; Anti-Money-Laundering — mandatory onboarding checks
MDR	Merchant Discount Rate — the fee a merchant pays on a payment (payments sales)
ACV / TCV	Annual / Total Contract Value — B2B deal size metrics
SQL / MQL	Sales-/Marketing-Qualified Lead — funnel qualification stages
POC / Pilot	Proof-of-Concept — limited trial to de-risk a B2B purchase
ICP	Ideal Customer Profile — the buyer type you target
TAT	Turnaround Time — e.g. onboarding/KYC speed (a common BFSI-SaaS value prop)
Cross-sell / Upsell / Share of wallet	Selling additional / higher products to an existing client; the RM growth engine
Churn / Retention / NRR	Losing / keeping customers; Net Revenue Retention (B2B expansion metric)
Expense ratio	Annual cost of a mutual fund as a % of assets — a key suitability/cost point
Bancassurance	Selling insurance through a bank's channel

14.2 The seller's core equation

> Value = (Outcome the buyer gets) − (Cost + Risk + Effort to switch)
> Your whole job is to raise the perceived outcome and lower the perceived cost, risk and switching effort.
>
> where: for retail the "outcome" is a life goal met; for B2B it's a business number improved. "Risk" in BFSI always includes compliance risk — de-risk it explicitly with pilots and compliance documentation.

14.3 Final pre-interview checklist

- Can I name the sub-industries and their regulators (RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, PFRDA, AMFI)? ✓
- Can I give the value prop + top objection for MF, term/health insurance, demat, loans, wealth/PMS? ✓

- Can I deliver Pitch A (retail MF), Pitch B (payment gateway), Pitch C (trust objection) from memory? ✓
- Can I explain distributor vs RIA, suitability, mis-selling, and KYC-as-part-of-the-sale? ✓
- Do I state my credentials accurately — hold NISM Series-XV, *pursuing* NISM X-A? ✓
- Can I map the B2B stakeholders and explain a POC? ✓
- Do I have my 30-60-90 plan and my three-sentence positioning ready? ✓
- Have I researched the specific employer's segment, product and buyer? ✓

> **Key takeaways — the whole guide in six lines:** (1) Sell into the domain you already understand — that's your moat. (2) Discover before you recommend; sell needs, not features. (3) Never guarantee market returns; suitability and honesty are the job, not the constraint. (4) Distributor ≠ adviser; KYC/AML is part of the sale. (5) In B2B, win the business, technical and compliance buyers and de-risk with a pilot. (6) State credentials accurately (hold Series-XV, pursuing X-A) and reframe the pivot as bringing desk-level rigour to the front line.